The Murder on the Seabed Express

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/39275544.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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The Murder on the Seabed Express

by Pok Chookity (Pok_Chookity)

Summary

A Harrowing Underwater Train Adventure. Or:

What happens when you put together a luxury train, a precious cargo of armor-grade ore, a team of Princesses led by Adora intent on protecting it from a Horde squad led by Catra intent on stealing it, and a Murder Mystery.

Notes

This story has 'murder' in its title, so you know what you're might be getting into. However it's also true that no archive warnings apply, and that's all I'm going to say ;)

You also may encounter some sexual innuendo.

It is the dead of night in the Fright Zone and Catra isn't happy. She's sitting on the floor of her room, pouring through diagrams and schematics that litter almost every available surface around her.

This time it was Hordak himself who gave her the task of procuring more armor-grade ore. With the rate at which Entrapta had to build new bots to replace those decimated by She-Ra, and with her inventing new ones and working on whatever it is she's doing with Hordak now, the Horde has nearly exhausted its sources, including the one in the Fright Zone.

Catra growls, throwing away another folder which joins a pile on her bed, and pinches the bridge of her nose, scrunching her tired eyes shut. As much as she hates to admit it, she's going to need help. She fishes a datapad from under the papers and looks up the location of the person she needs, pinpointing her in one of the Fright Zone's vehicle bays.

*

"Scorpia, there you are." Catra stops at the two feet sticking out from under the large vehicle propped up for maintenance.

At the sound of her voice the activity under the vessel ceases and Scorpia rolls out on a creeper. Her pincers are smeared with grease and she's made a few accidental smudges of it on her forehead.

"Hey, Catra!" she gets up, always pleased to see her bestie, and takes in the magicat's haggard appearance. "Gosh, were you still working at this hour?"

Catra could ask her the same thing - there's no one in the bay but them.

"The ore won't find itself," she grumbles. "And at this rate, it's not likely to be found at all..."

She gets distracted with the disarrayed state of the vehicle Scorpia was working on. "What's up with this thing?"

It's the same scorpion-shaped ship they went to the Princess Prom in. Scorpia told her it was hers, it had been in her family or something. Catra hasn't seen it since though - apparently it's been spending all its time in this hangar.

"Oh you know, just getting some work done. Needed to have the air brakes lines calibrated, change the engine lubricant intakes... But all in my off hours of course! So it wasn't moving very fast. But now it's almost done and soon Pointionita will be as good as new!"

"Pointionita?"

Scorpia nods enthusiastically. "She's fast, she's reliable - kind of like me, she has an excellent cargo compartment that can be used to transport prisoners... remember that? That was fun. And the best thing - all parts are pincer-friendly, so she's about the only thing that I can fix around here."

"Aha. Listen, I need you to look through our sea vessel specs with me. I've been over it for hours and I just can't find what I need. It's ridiculous." Catra throws her hands up and starts pacing, her tail lashing. "I *know* where we can get the ore. But we just can't get to it, because oh, it just had to be underwater."

"Oh."

"What?"

"Do we need to go underwater? Because Pointionita here... she can go underwater."

Catra stops and stares at her.

*

"It has come to our attention that the Horde has been scouring every possible source of armor-grade ore," Queen Angella announces to the war council.

All of the Princesses, along with Adora, Bow and the General of the Guard are in attendance, seated around the war table.

"And as it stands now, only one place remains where it can be acquired. Princess Mermista?"

Mermista startles slightly from lounging in her chair and takes her feet off the table. "Yeah... Right. It's in an underwater mine, but it would be totally impossible for them to get it, because it's like... super tightly guarded."

The General nods. "It is unlikely they'll attempt to seize the mine, Your Majesty. As far as we know, the Horde doesn't have any ships that could carry enough troops underwater."

"But... but!" Glimmer raises her hand.

"Yes, Glimmer?" Angella says as if she's been expecting it.

"But what about when it gets out of the mine? It has to be delivered somehow, right?"

"Yeah, there's a train," Mermista says. "A regular underwater express route to our most remote islands, it's very nice..." She notices the Queen giving her a look and gets back on track. "But the mining process is so slow that the ore only gets delivered once every few months - the train makes a stop near the mine, the ore cargo car gets inserted in it and it transports it to Salineas. And also, we don't use the ore for armor. We use it for peaceful stuff, like the sails of our ships - it's actually super light and bendy when it's processed just right. But unfortunately then it can also burn."

"Ooo, a train!" Sea Hawk, who has been there all along but was kind of forgotten, perks up excitedly at the word burn. "A train

that goes along the seabed, underwater, just like in that Mer-Mystery book, The Murder on the Seabed Express!"

"Yeah, and I need that book back!"

"So when is the next shipment due?" Bow says.

"It's in three days," Mermista supplies.

"Catra wouldn't miss this kind of opportunity," Adora says solemnly. "She will try to steal it, somehow. I just know it."

"Then we must protect it, and not allow the Horde to further strengthen itself," Angella says.

Adora nods assertively. "We'll be ready."

"I want to go! What if there'll be water that needs freezing?" Frosta says.

"I don't suppose there'll be any plants on the train?" Perfuma wonders, uncertain.

"I'm definitely going!" Sea Hawk says.

"Ugh, the train doesn't burn, it's underwater." Mermista tries to dissuade him.

"Exactly, my dearest. A Harrowing Underwater Train Adventure!"

"Uuuugh."

"Someone has to stay and guard the castle," Spinnerella says.

"Don't worry, it will be in good hands." Netossa snakes her arm around her elbow and nudges her.

Glimmer narrows her eyes at them suspiciously.

"Looks like we got out team." She nods to Bow and Adora.

*

"Is everyone comfortable back there?" Scorpia asks as she pilots Pointionita over the vast, clear expanse of the sea. "There are ration packs in the side compartment, if anyone's hungry."

"Oh, are they tiny?" Entrapta reaches with her hair to look.

"We're good, Force Captain. Ready for the mission," Lonnie says, and Kyle and Rogelio nod.

The four of them ride in the back of the ship's cockpit, while Scorpia and Catra occupy the front seats.

"You better be. Hordak will not look kindly at *anyone* if we fail." Catra eyes the endless landscape of water with unveiled dislike.

"I think this is the place!" Scorpia announces. "Everyone hold on!" She noses the ship down and the surface of water starts rushing at them.

"What? Are we going under already? Scorpia, whoa, whoa!" Catra clutches at a console with her claws, her eyes wide in horror.

The ship dives. Everyone is jolted, and the outside of the canopy becomes dim bluish-green.

"Scorpia!" Catra hisses.

"The vehicle's waterproof capacity has been officially confirmed!" Entrapta informs her recorder.

"You didn't TEST it?!" Catra glares.

The ship's hull chooses that moment to creak and she emits a startled squeak.

"There was no need," Entrapta says unperturbed.

"Ah, isn't it wonderful?" Scorpia gazes outside the canopy. "Oh look, a glowing jellyfish! And there's a starfish, ooo!"

Pointionita starts gliding over the sandy seabed with an unexpected speed, veering around occasional seaweed.

"Yeah, wonderful." Catra looks queasy. "Let's just get this over with."

*

"Two hundred whales per hour, and you can hardly feel a thing," Mermista comments, as she rummages inside a cabinet of the train's refreshments car.

Adora isn't sure how fast one whale is, or what a whale is, but for something that moves underwater the train does have a formidable speed - if the dim, steadily flowing seabed outside the windows is any indication.

"I can barely see anything out there." She cranes her neck to peer further to the back, noting that almost all light at their current depth comes from the train's windows. "How are we going to spot Catra when she attacks? I think I should go check on the cargo again."

"Oh, chill. If anyone tries to board this train, an alarm would go off. And we're already taking turns watching the cargo."

"Then we should've brought more guards. What's the point of not having any passengers if we can't fill this train with guards?"

"The point of having no passengers on the ore run which might get jacked is to not put people in danger. And we couldn't put in more guards. Understaffed, remember? Someone still has to guard the mine. And the castle. And lots of other stuff that's apparently also important."

"Then we should've brought in Brightmoon guards."

"Ugh, no offense, but have you seen those gals fight? Like anyone, ever? Honestly, sometimes I think Angella just keeps them for entourage. Buuuuut maybe don't tell her I said that.

Your General seems like she knows her stuff, but someone has to protect your castle too, right? Don't worry, we got this. Just sit back and enjoy the trip in style. Everything is fully automated - we bought this thing from Dryl, back when Entrapta was still like, good. But a long time ago, before she got obsessed with her robots. It drives itself - on a sea-friendly magic energy, of course, it makes food and drinks, and I've got a remote I can control things with... kelp salad!" She finds what she was rummaging around for.

Adora sits down at a table, still not looking fully convinced.

"So, are you ever going to tell us about you and Catra?" Mermista joins her and starts stirring her salad with a fork.

"What do you mean?"

"What is it with you two?"

"There's nothing with us two," Adora says and her eye twitches.

"Aha." Mermista peers at her skeptically.

"My dearest Mermista!" Sea Hawk startles them, announcing what he believes has to be his grand entrance.

"I'm going to go check on the cargo again!" Adora springs up and makes a beeline for the exit, thankful for the interruption.

"Ooo, kelp?"

"Uuuugh. I was talking to Adora."

*

"Is that you, villain? Come out and face me!" Bow jumps out from behind an ore crate, training his arrow into the darkness at the end of the cargo car. Rows and rows of tall crates that go almost to the ceiling fill nearly its entire space.

"Ugh, there's no villain, Bow," Glimmer says. "We would've known if there was a villain. Actually we would've felt it, with how fast this train's going, if anyone's tried to board it."

She looks out from a tall narrow window between the crate rows. "I don't know why everyone thought the Horde might try to steal this ore, it doesn't seem like it's even possible."

"Then why did you want to go?" Bow joins her, folding his weapon behind his back. "You seemed pretty eager about this mission."

"I thought it could be fun." She smiles. "Train travel... you know... I heard it's romantic," she says, dim ripples of reflected light from the window softly playing on her face.

"How's our cargo doing?" Adora booms, startling them.

"Ugh."

"So. You were the villain," Bow says, possibly a little annoyed but not showing it.

"Cargo is fine, Adora. Just as it was *ten* minutes ago," Glimmer says.

"Good. Great. Then I'll go check on the others." Adora stomps away determinedly.

"I think I know who definitely needs something romantic," Glimmer mutters.

*

Perfuma gives the mesh of vines she's grown to cover one of the doorframes a skeptical look and attempts to rearrange them. Frosta makes the sheet of ice she's made on the floor spurt menacing ice spikes.

"How are you guys doing?" Adora approaches.

"I think we're ready." Perfuma beams. "The vines I've brought with me are going to make a good trap should we need it."

"And I can slide our enemies straight into it!" Frosta declares.

"Good, good. Keep on practicing. I'm going to go the length of the train and double back." Adora leaves.

"Sheesh, hasn't she done that already?" Frosta says when she's out of earshot.

"She really needs some calming centering meditation," Perfuma agrees.

*

"Alright people, here we go!" Scorpia sends Pointionita into a turn, aiming it at the flat strip of the train track that softly undulates hugging the underwater landscape. The train's just appeared and is passing them, and they're going to come up on it from behind.

"Everyone hold on! Going into the slipstream!" Scorpia jams the throttle.

The ship shakes in turbulence and bursts right into the train's wake, where it evens out and follows its last car right above the rushing track.

"Scorpia!" Catra says in alarm, as the reduced drag starts sucking the ship in and the slanted back of the last train car starts to loom dangerously.

Behind, Entrapta squeaks excitedly. Kyle also squeaks.

"Aaaaaaand... Bump draft!" Scorpia says and touches the nose of the ship to the train, surprisingly gently.

"Locking in!" She flicks a control, and Pointionita's pincers, that weren't there just for the looks, extend and fix themselves to the train's hull.

"And engines off! Yes!" Scorpia throws her pincers up.

Catra appraises her. Apparently she really likes driving her ship.

"Was that... necessary?" Kyle says, looking more pale than usual.

Rogelio growls in agreement.

"Ah, I bet they didn't even feel it," Scorpia says.

*

In the refreshments car, the tableware vibrates slightly. So does the crystal chandelier.

"What was that?" Adora says in alarm.

She's just finished her backtrack, which involved startling Glimmer and Bow again, and has discovered that Mermista and Sea Hawk have started a little sea food feast going.

"We need to check on the cargo. For the honor of Grayskull!"

She-Ra appears and pivots to rush towards trouble. "Ow!" She bumps her head on a doorframe that is suddenly too low for her.

"Wouldn't it be more effective to move inside the train if you're smaller?" Sea Hawk observes.

"Yeah, we don't even know if anything's going on yet," Mermista says.

She-Ra huffs, turns back into Adora and lunges down the corridor.

*

"Are we going to go outside?" Kyle stares out the ship's canopy, at where its nose is positioned just under the train's rear hatch.

"Haven't you read the brief?" Catra grumbles.

"Allow me to demonstrate!" Entrapta takes out a complicated-looking datapad and presses a button.

An inflatable corridor bursts out from a compartment on the nose of the ship and extends to the train, attaching itself around the hatch.

"Suctioning in, pumping out water... All done!" Entrapta says. "No wait! Did I install an alarm system on that thing?" She taps her chin with a hair tendril. "This was so long ago... Well, just in case!" She pushes another button, and something crackles. "A tiny localized EMP pulse, we can go in now! Good thing I still have the factory override lock code too, otherwise even She-Ra wouldn't have been able to break through that hatch."

Catra pulls a trapdoor in the cabin's floor open. "Tasers check! Gaining a stealth entrance is a priority, but be ready for anything!"

*

So far, everything has gone smoothly. They haven't encountered any Princesses in the first cars they stealthily sneaked through. However, Catra's plan didn't assume that they'll remain undetected forever. So she's ready for it when Kyle emits a sudden yelp, slides on an icy patch of floor and ends up entangled in a mesh of vines that suddenly springs up to block a threshold.

They dive for cover and scan the corridor ahead, tasers out.

"Anyone see them?" Catra peers out, ignoring Kyle's frantic thrashing.

"I can't see anyone," Scorpia says.

"I think it's just a booby trap," Lonnie observes.

"Huh," Catra says, straightening up. "They all must be guarding the ore."

Rogelio and Lonnie rush to get Kyle out.

"Seriously Kyle. Watch where you're going next time, you can get yourself killed one of these days," Lonnie says, and Rogelio growls in agreement.

*

"The ore is fine, Adora." Glimmer gives her a slightly exasperated look.

Everyone has gathered in the cargo compartment to make sure that was the case, but Adora isn't about to relax that easily. "We still need to check the train. Glimmer, can you teleport me and Bow to see if we haven't been boarded anywhere?"

"She won't have to."

Adora freezes, because the drawling voice that said that is so unmistakably, painfully and longingly familiar.

"Heeey Adora."

Adora spins, and sure enough, Catra is there, leisurely strolling in through the cargo hold's open doors like she's been invited, a smirk on her face. Scorpia, Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle follow her inside and flank her, aiming tasers.

"Don't move, Horde scum!" Glimmer charges up her magic blasts, and the rest poise their respective powers and weapons. It's a standoff.

Adora's hand goes to the hilt of her sword but she lingers when she sees Entrapta bringing up the rear - she still remembers her First Ones virus. Maybe it's better to see if she doesn't have another, before she has to expose She-Ra - it looks like Catra didn't bring a big team and she doesn't need to transform for this fight yet.

"Catra. I knew it would be you." Adora stares at her and studies their group. "Looks like we outnumber you, and we have She-Ra.

You really should've brought more troops. Is this all that Hordak's willing to spare for you these days?"

"Hey, watch it!" Lonnie says.

Catra smirks. She wanted to bring more troops, but considering the amount of ore they'd have to load on Pointionita, they'll be lucky if they don't have to leave Kyle behind. So she came up with something else.

She snorts. "We didn't even know you'd be here. I guess Angella orders She-Ra to guard ore shipments these days, huh? What, nothing more important for the hero of all of Etheria to do? Run out of kingdoms to save?"

"That was your plan Catra? To just insult me until I give you the ore?" Adora says, feeling like she has an upper hand.

Catra smirks.

The plan was actually pretty brilliant. To get inside the train, so Entrapta could gain control of its systems. To goad Adora - because of course it would be Adora, who else is going to guard the last source of ore - into combat, so she would follow her just as she had every time they fought before. To fall back towards Pointionita, luring as many of the ore defenders as possible out of the cargo hold and into the back of the train, and making sure to taser out Sparkles, who'd undoubtedly jump into the center of action too. Then for Entrapta to use her device to remotely uncouple the cargo car both from the front and from the back of the train, making the front keep rolling and the back drop behind, while they'd jump into Pointionita, detach, reattach to the cargo car, take out whomever might be left inside and then transfer the ore to their ship at their leisure, while Adora and her friends would just helplessly sit around because they can't get out from the train underwater, and Sparkles, when she comes to, wouldn't know where exactly the cargo car is.

And after they're done maybe she'd give them control of the train back - so they could limp to the shore and tell everyone of their crushing humiliating defeat. No other reason, obviously.

It's a shame she doesn't get to go through with it. All the lights in the train suddenly go out.

"Nobody move!" Catra shouts in complete darkness.

"You don't move, Catra!" Adora shouts back.

"Adora, if you try something, I swear..."

"You're the one trying something! For the Honor of Grayskull!"

She-Ra's glowing light appears.

Train's lights come back on at the same time. Everyone reassesses the opposing side and resumes the standoff with renewed purpose. Everyone except Lonnie.

"Guys..." She looks through a large window in the door to the next car behind her, horrorstruck. "It's Kyle!"

There, on the floor lies Kyle, his body unnaturally pale and twisted and his tongue lolling out.

Everyone stares, astounded.

"Is he... dead?" Frosta gasps.

"No-no honey, he can't be dead," Perfuma tries to assure her but doesn't look too convinced herself.

Rogelio lets out a very distraught growl and tries to open the door. It's not budging, he takes a swing at the glass with a taser but the glass doesn't break either.

"How did he get there? He was just next to me, with Rogelio!" Lonnie says.

"What did you do?" Catra hisses at She-Ra.

"Me? That wasn't us!"

The lights go out again, but this time She-Ra's glow makes it possible to make out what's happening near them.

"Everyone stay calm!" She-Ra shouts.

"Everyone keep close!" Catra shouts.

Lights turn on. Everyone looks around frantically, checking on the others.

"Sea Hawk? Where's Sea Hawk? He was just here!" Mermista looks both ways to the next train cars but he's nowhere to be seen.

Neither is Kyle's presumed body.

"But... Where did he go?" Scorpia gasps, seeing that too.

Rogelio slams with his shoulder against the door but it's still closed.

"Kyle?" Lonnie tries her badge. There's just static.

"Fascinating..." Entrapta says.

"What kind of game is this, Catra?" She-Ra trains her sword at her.

"I don't play games, Adora!" Catra crackles her taser.

"Well what kind of convoluted plan is this then? What- is this some sort of spectacle to make us drop our guard and let you steal the ore?"

Catra frowns. This isn't *her* spectacle.

"Wow. Didn't think you had it in you, Adora. Using Kyle like that? What, did you think I'll buy this pathetic attempt to thwart my mission?"

"It's *you* who's doing it!"

"I don't need to do that to steal the ore, I can just take it!"

"Oh, I'd like to see you try!"

"With pleasure!"

"Are you two serious?" Mermista glares at them. "We should be trying to find Sea Hawk! And that other one..."

"Then we should be trying to make Catra tell us where they are!" She-Ra grits her teeth.

"Adora, what if it's not them?" Bow says, unsure.

Mermista takes the remote out of her pocket, ignoring the weapons still being aimed, and points it at the locked door. "Um, guys? I can't control anything on the train anymore. And it says all the outer doors are blocked."

"They must've done this," Glimmer says.

Catra glances at Entrapta. The tech Princess looks really confused, poking at her datapad. Catra's ears twitch - if that means she's lost her control of the train systems then they can no longer detach the cars and her plan really has been thwarted.

"But how could they get to Sea Hawk who was behind us without us seeing?" Bow says, remembering that She-Ra had already been glowing.

She-Ra lowers her sword slightly, unsure.

"We've got to find the murderer!" Frosta says, excited.

"We're still not sure if anyone has been murdered..." Perfuma says.

"Alright." Catra sweeps the opposing side with a glance. "Lonnie, Rogelio, keep on them. Make sure they don't try anything."

She motions for Scorpia and Entrapta to move back so they can talk.

"Wait, what are you doing?" She-Ra says.

"Taking five, do you mind?"

She-Ra stares at her incredulously, but realizes it could be a good opportunity to do the same. She nods to Perfuma and Frosta to keep guard, while she and the rest move to huddle in the back, making sure they're out of Catra's sensitive hearing range.

"I still think it might be them, they could've boarded the front of the train too," Glimmer whispers.

"But wouldn't we have felt that? And it should've shaken us much harder if they weren't in the train's wake," Bow says.

"But we can't know that for sure until we check and we can't let Catra steal the ore," She-Ra says.

"So let's just jump them," Glimmer says. "You know we can take them, right? That's one problem solved, even if it's not them."

Bow looks appalled. "We're the good guys, we can't do that."

"Um, Bow, they've come to steal our ore, I say we can," Glimmer says.

"Okay, but we don't know what's really going on. What if we should be working together to save our friends right now instead of fighting each other?" Bow says.

"What I said." Mermista nods.

"Why would we need their help?" Glimmer says.

"Whoever did this got Sea Hawk and Kyle without us even noticing. There could be two of them or more. What if it's not even a person? What if it was a magic monster?" Bow gets increasingly agitated. "It's actually really surprising how often that happens to us."

She-ra glances at him. Scorpia did save them all in the Northern Reach.

Glimmer chews on her lip, not happy with that idea.

"Can I just teleport somewhere and get help?"

"There's nothing around on this stretch, and it's at least three more hours until we reach the shore. Assuming we're all still around by then," Mermista says.

Glimmer groans quietly. "Then it's going to be a while."

She-Ra glances at Catra's side, where another hushed conversation is happening.

"I've lost control of all the train systems, and the rear hatch is definitely blocked," Entrapta confirms Catra's worst expectations.

"Then we must get it back, or we're never getting the ore," Catra says quietly.

"Grrr," Rogelio says, standing close enough to hear them.

"Fine, and we must find Kyle," Catra adds.

"Were some of them hiding in the back of the train?" Scorpia looks worried. "But if they're the ones that trapped us, why aren't they attacking?"

"Good question," Entrapta taps her chin with a hair tendril. "What we know for sure is that we are trapped until I can get to the

front cabin and regain control."

"They won't just let us do that." Catra glances at She-Ra's side.

Her plan for getting the ore never intended being able to win the fight they were going to start. And if one breaks out now, with no means of escape, they're done.

"Ugh, we don't have a choice," she says. "We'll have to go along with what ever this is, until we can get the control back and can get on with our plan again."

She straightens up and looks at She-Ra. "Are you about done, Princess?"

"We are, are you?"

They all get back towards the center of the hold.

"I propose we forget about the ore and search the train. And we should restore the control of the doors," Catra says.

She-Ra squints at her. "Why? Because this is also a part of your plan?"

Of course! Typical Catra!

"No, because we don't want to be stuck in here, with a possible murderer or murderers. And we want to find our teammate, who we hope is just missing. Isn't this what you want too?"

She-Ra studies her. It makes sense. But this is Catra.

"How did you get here? Do you have a transport?"

"We swam here, duh," Catra says. "On the back of a rainbow colored dolphin."

She-Ra glares. "Well, then we're not trapped because Glimmer can just teleport everyone to your ship, if it ever comes to that," she says, smug.

"Actually, she can't!" Entrapta says. "I've installed a permanent teleportation dampening shield on the ship, so no one can get there now!"

Catra glances at her. She really shouldn't look so excited about that.

"I can easily find out if that's true," Glimmer says.

"Not if you want to get all glitchy again," Catra says.

She-Ra groans inwardly. Her brain is starting to hurt from trying to keep up with every implication of everything that may or may not be happening here. Glimmer's right. If it turns out it's them they can just take them.

"Fine. We can find out what's happening here first. But if you try *anything*, Catra..." She gives her a very meaningful stare. "And someone will remain here to guard the ore."

"Then someone will stay with them because I'm not leaving any of your people unwatched until I know what's going on," Catra says.

She-Ra doesn't like it, but it works. "Glimmer, Bow?"

"Scorpia?"

Scorpia nods readily.

"Entrapta will need to go to the front cabin to fix the train," Catra says.

"We can wait with that," She-Ra says.

"Or, maybe I said that because not going there is exactly what I need her to do," Catra smirks.

She-Ra looks about ready to explode. Or to strangle her, Catra isn't sure.

"Then I'll just go wherever she goes and make sure she doesn't do anything before I tell her to!" She-Ra says.

Catra's ear twitches. Entrapta is her only means of still completing her mission. Not to mention what Hordak would do if she loses her, if the Princesses somehow lure her over to their side. They're good at that. She clenches her teeth, remembering how she 'lost' Adora, and Shadow Weaver's reaction.

"Then I guess I'm coming with you to make sure you don't do anything either."

"Can we go find Sea Hawk already?" Mermista steps up to She-Ra.

"Aww, worried about leaving the mighty She-Ra alone with us?" Catra purrs.

"And Kyle?" Lonnie glares.

"Fine. Go with Rogelio, let me know as soon as you do."

"Perfuma, Frosta, you'll have to watch them," She-Ra says.

"Wait, why are we separating?" Perfuma says worriedly.

"Because we don't want to argue who to search for first?" Catra says. And because doing both things as soon as possible is exactly what she needs.

Perfuma huffs.

Catra doesn't like how outmatched they are in the formed teams. Only Scorpia might be able to hold her own - despite often showing complete ineptitude she was able to stand up even to She-Ra, at least from what Catra's heard about the battle of the Pass. Although she's not sure how much of that was true, a roaring plant golem? But then Scorpia really did knock her out in the Northern Reach... In a fight she'll be most formidable.

Sparkles and Arrow Boy must've been appointed to stay with the ore for the same reason.

In the other group the princesses would get an upper hand with their magic. And it would take more than just her and Entrapta to take down She-Ra and the water princess combined.

If this really is some weird Princess ploy, she can only hope she gets Entrapta close enough to her target and can buy her enough time when they decide to attack. She realizes she wishes there really was a murder mystery happening here.

"Ready, Princess?" She looks at She-Ra.

"Ready. But don't even think you'll still be able to steal the ore. I'm watching you." She-Ra narrows her eyes at her sternly.

"Fine, *watch* me," Catra smirks.

She-Ra glares at her and marches up to the still locked door, raising her sword. She smashes it open with a few blows which seem to be more vehement than necessary.

"You couldn't have done that earlier, Adora?" Lonnie says pointedly.

"You couldn't have stopped aiming tasers at people earlier, Lonnie?" She-Ra replies.

They exchange glares, and the teams move out into their respective parts of the train, eyeing the members from opposing sides warily.

"This is going to end well," Glimmer mutters.

The sounds of footsteps recede and she, Bow and Scorpia are left alone.

They study each other for a while. It becomes clear that none of them is going to attack, so they pretend to study something else.

Then Scorpia attempts to hum, but drops it. Glimmer clears her throat.

The silence starts to feel awkward.

"So," Scorpia says. "Anything interesting happening in Brightmoon lately?"

"Ugh. We prefer not to swap small talk with our enemy," Glimmer says.

"Really? I thought we're all friends now, because of the, you know. Mysterious stuff that we're almost certain is happening here?"

Glimmer snorts. "Don't think I've forgotten how you dangled me over the edge. Or threw me into an ice pit."

"Ah, come on, I knew you could teleport. I don't think you mean that, remember all those other fun times we had together? What about that time when you set your ship on fire and then used it to burn our ship... no, wait, that wasn't it... Oh, I know, when we came to Brightmoon and tried to blow up your rune stone... Hmm, that wasn't it either... Gosh, I was certain there was something..."

"Sooo," Bow rushes to interject. "If we really are friends, maybe you could tell us how you were going to get the ore? Since, you know, it shouldn't really matter now." He uses his best friendly regular guy impression, not really hoping it will work but trying anyway.

"Oh, I see what you did!" Scorpia nods appreciatively. "But sorry, no. That is a top secret information. And I'm a vault for secrets."

The silence stretches again.

"So. Anything interesting happening in the Fright Zone lately?" Bow says.

*

Catra and Entrapta carefully advance, checking compartments, looking into the luggage cupboards, everywhere where a person could be hiding or could've been hidden. She-Ra and Mermista keep close by, doing the same, and with everyone constantly checking on everyone, and also being on constant guard for possible murderers or magic monsters, the journey towards the front of the train progresses slowly. The silence begins to feel oppressive here too.

"Entrapta, how can you be helping them?" Mermista says. "They'll just use the ore to build more weapons to use against us. Are you this mad at us for leaving you behind?"

"I'm not mad. I just love building weapons! It's so exciting!!"

"Ugh."

She-Ra ducks another doorframe and Catra cackles. "Oh, I get it now, why you wear that stupid tiara. It's to tell you when the ceiling is too low so you won't knock your dumb head on stuff."

"It is not for feeling the ceiling!" She-Ra exclaims, exasperated. The spot where she knocked her head on the doorframe earlier chooses that moment to sting.

"Really? Then what purpose does it serve? Like from a practical standpoint."

She-Ra glares at her. "And what purpose does your headpiece serve? Like from a practical standpoint."

Catra growls. Because Adora knows perfectly well that she likes that headpiece. "It keeps the hair out of my face, genius."

"Well so does my tiara!"

And if She-Ra's gorgeous, magically flowing hair could never get in her face anyway, Catra doesn't need to know that.

"Finally," Mermista declares as they enter the train's front cabin, having not found anything suspicious on their way there.

It turns out to be empty as well, save but for the glow of instruments. The dim seabed and the train track rush at them outside the front window.

"But... This doesn't make sense, where is he? What did we miss?" Mermista looks around, lost. "And also we've checked all the doors, all bolted from the inside, how could the Horde get in this part of the train? The bolts would've been broken. Looks like it really wasn't them."

She-Ra looks at Catra in baffled surprise.

Catra narrows her eyes. Could hanging around Princesses have made Adora that good an actress? And how is this still a part of a ploy?...

Entrapta bounds to one of the consoles and opens a panel with her hair.

"Hey!" She-Ra says, and Catra gets ready to fight.

But She-Ra makes no real attempt to stop the tech Princess, still thinking of Mermista's observation.

"Hmm..." Entrapta says, looking confused. "I don't think we can fix the train. The entire control assembly has been removed."

"Can you replace it?" Catra says, trying to sound calm.

"Of course I can! If I had the parts. Which I don't have."

Catra's ear twitches. She has a bad feeling about this. She glances at She-Ra and activates her badge.

*

In the back of the train the other team hasn't been having any success with finding anything either. One good thing about that is that they didn't find any signs that Kyle had been injured, back where his presumed body had been laying. But that doesn't mean he couldn't have been shot with something like a poison dart.

These troubling thoughts run through Lonnie's head when her badge crackles to life and Perfuma jumps, aiming her vines at her.

"This is just a communication device." Lonnie gives her incredulous look and activates it.

"Are you at the back of the train?" Catra's voice says.

"We're just finishing, and we didn't find anyone."

Rogelio growls with distress.

"I need you to check that *everything* is okay back there," Catra's voice says.

Lonnie nods and goes to the small porthole near the back hatch that they'd used to enter. She looks outside and her expression changes. "Force Captain Catra. We have a problem," she says, dumbstruck.

There's nothing outside the porthole but the empty seabed and the rushing track.

Frosta cranes her neck to see past her. "Ha, is your dolphin gone?"

In the cargo car, Scorpia, who has been listening in on her badge, bolts up. "Pointionita is gone?!"

She grabs an astounded Glimmer by her shoulders and shakes her, ignoring Bow's protesting yelp.

"But what could've happened to her? How are we going to find her again? How are we going to get out?"

In the train's cabin Catra scrunches her eyes shut and silently allows herself a long suffering groan of frustration. Because they can't.

Even if by some miracle it was Kyle, and he's on the ship now, he wouldn't be able to bring it back because he doesn't know how to pilot it. But it couldn't have been Kyle, because the exit was blocked, so he still has to be here, somewhere. If he's even alive.

And this means she can forget about asking Entrapta if maybe she still can come up with something to salvage her plan. They're never getting the ore now.

"Scorpia, calm down," she says, resigned. "Pointionita floats. And she has a tracking beacon."

"Oh gosh, you're right! We'll still be able to find her later!"

If the Princesses don't take them prisoner. But why hasn't it happened already?

She looks at She-Ra, who still watches her with that bewildered expression. If this was all a ploy, if they went as far as to get rid of their ship, making sure they can't escape for exactly this very purpose? What, did Adora just want them to stick around so they could hang?

There's only one other explanation.

"Well?" She glares.

"Well what?" She-Ra looks at her.

"Go ahead. You've got us. Attack us."

"But... It really wasn't us."

"No?"

"No! And it really wasn't you?"

"No!"

"Then can we please stop doing this?" She-Ra groans.

"Fine." Catra rolls her eyes.

"You two are unbelievable..." Mermista mutters under her breath.

Catra taps her badge. "Just... Forget about the ore Scorpia. Get back to me. Lonnie, Rogelio do it too. We have more pressing matters now."

She glances at She-Ra. Maybe they really do need to work together. And not just because Kyle is really... missing and they don't know what they might be dealing with. If she helps them solve this, if she makes herself useful, then maybe when they get to the shore they would be too uncomfortable about taking them all prisoner. Those Princesses are real bleeding hearts types.

"I think we should stay together," she says.

She-Ra gives her a look, noticing how that sounds.

"I think so too."

*

They are nearing the refreshments car, where they decided to reconvene, when She-Ra stops, staring forward. "What is that?"

There, on the floor lies a small object.

"It's Sea Hawk's flaming sword!" Mermista lunges towards it and picks it up.

"Fascinating, it was not present when we passed here last time!" Entrapta says.

"But there was no one back here," She-Ra says, and glances at Catra.

"Lonnie?" Catra uses the comms.

The other group is heading down the corridor.

"We found that sea guy's sword," Catra continues through Lonnie's badge. "Keep your eyes open."

"Hold on," Lonnie stops, hearing something.

She taps on her badge and the sound it emits comes echoing from someplace else. She looks inside a compartment, and there, in plain view on the floor lies a Horde communication badge, which can only be Kyle's.

"But we've checked here," Perfuma says. "I remember we did."

"And someone had to switch it back on because we couldn't pin point it earlier..." Lonnie picks it up and both she and Rogelio stare at it.

*

All the occupants of the Seabed Express have gathered in the refreshments car. In light of recent events nobody really wanted to be in small groups anymore and the ore has been completely forgotten.

Mermista stands, gazing gloomily out the window at the murky and dim patterns of seabed streaking past it.

"Here's what we know for certain so far," she says. "Whoever left the sword and the badge had done it after the Horde ship got detached. Which means that the person or persons, or whatever is doing it, is still here."

A huge glowing jellyfish streaks past the window, illuminating the car with a flash of light.

"And apparently they also wanted us to know about it because it's unlikely they accidentally left both objects where we can surely

find them," she concludes.

"What if it was Kyle or Sea Hawk?" Perfuma says, sitting at a table.

"Or both!" Frosta adds.

Mermista has thought of that. But she can't see how, or why.

"It's never the obvious one. It wasn't the obvious one in The Murder on the Seabed Express. And all this is starting to feel a lot like that book."

Another jellyfish flashes.

"Okay, if it was someone else, how did they get here?" Catra reclines in a chair.

"Maybe on your ship?" Adora looks at her from across the table. She had finally reverted to her normal self after getting frustrated with the wings of her tiara clipping the ceiling.

"All our ships get checked before missions, remember?" Catra says.

It's something they considered once - hiding inside a vehicle and sneaking out of the Fright Zone to see what was out there. Back when Adora still wanted to be with her, to rule the world together.

Adora's expression flickers to something like longing but she catches herself.

"Maybe they got here from the mine?" Lonnie suggests.

"No, the cargo hold only had ore in it, we checked when it got attached," Glimmer says.

"Maybe they were on the train all along?" Scorpia raises her pincer.

"But the train was checked to make sure there were no passengers," Mermista says.

"Then it *is* a magic monster!" Bow gasps.

"I feel like we should've seen it by now," Adora says, slightly disappointed.

"Then, do you know what that means?" Bow says, agitated. "It can only be one of us!!"

Third jellyfish flashes.

"Of course it's not one of us, Bow," Glimmer says.

"How do you know?"

"Maybe they didn't check the train well enough. They didn't know someone could be hiding on it."

"Then it's not Kyle or Sea Hawk, right?" Perfuma says.

"Why would either of them even do this?" Mermista looks at her incredulously.

"On a more pressing matter, where are they now, and where whoever is doing this is hiding?" Catra says. "We've checked everywhere. So think, people, air ducts, service tunnels?"

"No, there's nothing big enough on this train." Entrapta types on her datapad absentmindedly.

"Maybe they're in a box somewhere!" Frosta says. "Locked inside together! And then Sea Hawk comes to, and sees Kyle's pale and probably lifeless body, and goes AAAAAAAAGHH!"

Her shrill scream imitates Sea Hawk's surprisingly well. Everyone stares at her.

"A BOX!" Adora jumps up, slamming her hands on the table. "They're in the ore crates!"

"No, already checked there," Glimmer shakes her head. "All full of ore, nowhere to hide."

Adora sits back, kind of disappointed.

"But they have to be here. There has to be a place we don't know of," Scorpia says.

"Or... whoever doing this is *invisible*! And made them invisible too!" Bow gasps.

"There's no such thing," Glimmer says.

"Or... it's a shape-shifter!" Bow looks around the others, nervously.

"That would've been fun, but there's no such thing either," Catra says.

"Rogelio, what do you think?" Lonnie says. He has been quiet through the entire exchange. "Rogelio?"

He's also not present in the room.

"Rogelio!" Lonnie springs to her feet, followed by others.

"He was here when we started!" Scorpia says.

"Did it happen again?" Adora stares around.

A sound of a flushing toilet comes from a distance and after a moment Rogelio enters from a corridor.

"Rogelio!" Lonnie hisses. "You know we shouldn't separate, what were you thinking?"

Rogelio spreads his hands and shakes his head.

"Um, Rogelio?" Catra says, and something in the deliberately calm and controlled tone of her voice makes Adora glance at her in alarm. "Could you walk over here?"

Everyone turns to Catra this time, feeling that something is off. She's standing so she has a view of the dim corridor Rogelio has entered from, and her nocturnal eyes are letting her see more than others.

"Grr?" Rogelio says, tensing.

"Because there's someone. Standing. Behind you."

A string of glowing jellyfishes flashes by, illuminating the car, and everyone sees it. There, in the corridor, stands a tall hooded figure, all dressed in black and poised to attack. It's hard to tell if it's a he or a she with the bulkiness of its attire, and its face is covered, but they can feel its eyes on them.

"It's the murderer!" Frosta exclaims.

"It's real!" Perfuma gasps.

"Get them!" Catra shouts.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!"

The figure launches away and everyone lunges after it.

Glimmer charges her teleport. "We can cut them off!"

"Glimmer, no! It could be a trap, there could be more of them back there!" Bow shouts in warning.

She groans and they follow the others on foot.

The chase is on. The figure is surprisingly fast and agile. It ducks a blast from She-Ra's sword, rolls under a vine from Perfuma, narrowly evades a net arrow from Bow and a magic blast from Glimmer, overturns a couple cabinets as it goes, making She-Ra stumble into them and Catra smash into her mid-leap. Then it changes tactics. It takes out a taser - possibly taken from Kyle, takes cover at a threshold and starts firing down the corridor, making everyone duck. Lonnie and Rogelio return fire. Glimmer

tries a teleport pounce, but the figure is ready, firing where she should appear, and she has to pounce back mid teleport.

"Frosta!" Mermista catches her breath. "Where did you put your ice traps?"

"Near the cargo hold, in the back half!"

"Can you unfreeze them from here?"

Frosta concentrates. "Done!"

Mermista extends her hands, straining. It would've been so much easier if she could just use all that water around them without flooding the train... "Ugh... Can't really move it from here, but can lift it..." "Freeze it again!"

"Frozen!"

"What did you do?" She-Ra pants, still untangling herself from the broken cabinets.

"We've just blocked the way from the cargo car with ice, they can't get to the back of the train now!" Mermista says.

"We got them!" She-Ra springs up and transforms her sword into a shield. "Follow me!" She charges down the corridor, deflecting taser blasts, allowing others to go in her wake.

The figure jumps and lunges away. It reaches the exit from the car and locks the door after itself. She-Ra gets to it and starts smashing it open - it budges, but it's too slow.

Glimmer sees that due to their momentary stop, the figure has made it to the end of the next car and is about to disappear out of sight behind the door there. She can't let that happen. She teleports.

"Glimmer!" Bow shouts.

She appears in the car the figure would've entered. But it's empty.

"What?"

She teleports to the next. And the next. And finally into the cargo hold. Which just like everything else is completely empty of sinister figures.

She rushes to the back of the car, and finds that the way forth is just as Mermista said, completely blocked with a solid wall of ice. She checks between the rows of crates, again, but there's still no one there.

"Oh come on!" she shouts.

Noise advances from the direction she's come and the rest pour into the cargo hold, finally catching up with her.

"Glimmer!" Bow rushes to her, relieved. "Why did you do that, it was too dangerous!"

"We've lost them!" she says.

"I know. We haven't seen anyone back there either. But can we talk about how that was too dangerous to do alone?"

"Urgh! What are we missing?" Glimmer groans in frustration.

"They had to disappear somewhere in this part of the train," Catra says.

"We're taking it apart if that's what it takes!" She-Ra looks around for something to dismantle.

"Okay," Glimmer says, flustered. "Is there another part of this train which could even *hypothetically* be large enough for someone to hide in? And I don't care if there aren't supposed to be any!" She glares at Entrapta.

"I don't know... maybe below?" Scorpia looks at the floor. "It would be all filled with machinery, but you said..."

"Yes," Glimmer says and stomps her foot on the floor. It sounds dull, no hidden compartments.

They start stomping, searching. Catra doesn't care for doing that barefoot and observes it with disdain, leaning on an ore crate.

"Can't you just teleport and look?" she tells Glimmer.

"And get stuck in a wall?"

"Wait, that's actually a possibility?" Mermista looks startled.

"Aren't you going to help?" She-Ra says.

"Fine." Catra remembers that she does need to help. "There." She stomps. And it sounds hollow.

Everyone freezes and stares at her.

Catra scans the floor around her and spots a small indentation near the ore crate. She hooks a claw in it and pulls, and a whole panel of the floor hinges open, where it looked like a seamless solid surface just a moment ago. Below it, a dim tunnel-like space is visible.

"There's a tunnel. Under the floor." She-Ra stands next to her, gazing down incredulously.

They turn to look at Entrapta.

The tech Princess fidgets her hair tendrils. "I'm not sure. I had so many projects going back then, maybe I got distracted with my robot phase and made this to allow robot butlers to move around, but then decided the train would be making and delivering the food by itself and forgot to revise the blueprints? But that definitely shouldn't be there."

"We're going in!" Glimmer says.

"We can't all go in, we'll be just crawling in a file," She-Ra says. "And maybe Bow is right about teleporting into the unknown. Someone should go in while others look above for other exits, teleporting might be more useful there."

"Ugh, fine."

Catra lowers to the floor and carefully peers into the tunnel.

"Way to the back is blocked with ice down there too, the water must've gotten in." She straightens out. "Only one way to go. Scorpia, you Lonnie, Rogelio and Entrapta help them look above."

"But Wild Cat."

"You won't even fit in there. But I'm going in," Catra steps to the opening.

She-Ra looks at her questioningly.

"I can see in the dark, duh."

"And I'm She-Ra. I can glow in the dark."

"You sure about that?" Catra nods down the small tunnel pointedly. There's enough room to crawl on all fours but not if you're eight feet tall.

"Fine. But you're not going alone," She-Ra says and reverts to Adora.

"Aw, worried something might happen to me?"

Adora pauses, and decides to be honest. "Yes. I am."

"That never stopped you before," Catra mutters and jumps down into the tunnel.

Adora follows her in, frowning.

"Hey, I could've gone too, I'm small!" Frosta says.

"Maybe some other time, okay? When we're sure there aren't any murderers down there," Perfuma dissuades her.

"How come you Princesses don't use flashlights?" Lonnie observes, wishing she hadn't made Kyle carry all of theirs.

"But... We have magic?" Perfuma says.

"Can you see anything?" Adora says, crouching with Catra on the bottom, her eyes haven't adjusted yet. Catra leans to see past her, and Adora is suddenly aware of how close she is.

"No one there," Catra leans back and studies her. "What?"

"Nothing. You go first," Adora nods into the tunnel.

"So you could watch my back?" Catra smirks.

"No. I don't trust you to watch mine."

"Whatever."

*

The tunnel's darkness is broken only by occasional faint machinery indicators and Adora can barely make out Catra in front of her. They must've gone the length of a few cars already but haven't found anyone or any other exits so far.

"Do you have to keep flicking your tail at my face?"

"I dunno, do you have to keep crawling so close to me?"

"I'm not, you're slowing down on purpose!"

"Am I? Or maybe you just like it?"

"Okay, why are you acting like this?!" Adora stops, and tries to straighten out in the small space.

Catra pivots and glares at her over her shoulder, her mismatched eyes faintly glowing. "Now? You want to talk now? When we're looking for a possible murderer in a tunnel in an underwater train?"

"Yes now! I tried talking to you before and it didn't work, so maybe now would actually be better!"

"Ugh, whatever. I think we've talked enough." Catra turns and resumes crawling.

Adora follows. "I don't understand it! Why don't you believe I never wanted you to be second best?"

"Because I've seen plenty of evidence to the contrary," Catra hisses.

"Do you think I'm lying?"

"Just let it go, Adora!"

"No, I'm not going to let it go!"

Adora feels like she's had enough of people telling her to let go.

"Is this really what you want? Do you really want us to fight forever? You don't even like it in the Horde!"

"I said stop it," Catra growls.

She won't let Adora make her think about this again. Because even with everything that's happened, even with the way Adora's been treating her, even with her burning need to prove to Adora that she was wrong, that she's not worse than her, even after the Battle for Brightmoon there is still something. She can't call it doubt, or uneasiness, or nostalgia. She doesn't know what to call it. It simply doesn't work like this - instantly and completely forgetting everything she ever felt about Adora, even if she's got all the reasons why she should. Because Adora broke her promise, because she left her. Because winning, coming up on top is what

she really wants. And because Hordak's motivational lever has made it clear to her that she also has to. So Adora will just have to stop.

"No, Catra, you stop it!" Adora reaches forward angrily and Catra lets out a squeak.

"Let go of my tail!"

Instead Adora pulls, making her slide and drop to the floor, and Catra hisses.

"Let go of me!"

She tries to kick with her foot but misses, lets out her claws and pivots back, lunging. The force of her impact pushes Adora against the wall with a loud thud, and Catra feels good about it, about the way the air escapes Adora's lungs and her body grinds into hers. *That's* what she wants.

"Catra, stop!"

"You wish!"

"No I mean it! I think the wall is giving!"

"Are you serious?"

The wall does give and both of them drop down into a dark nothingness, and for one terrifying instant Catra imagines they might be falling out of the train, but instead they roll down a short inclined shaft and hit the bottom of some sort of a compartment, which promptly closes above them.

Everything goes completely dark. The sound of their ragged breathing fills the enclosed space as they try to get their wind and bearings back.

"Catra? Are you okay?"

"Ugh. I'm fine."

Adora tries to feel around herself. "Oh no. I think we *are* in a box. And... I think there really *is* a body in here. I can feel it with my back..."

"Adora..."

"What do we do?" Adora says in a voice full of dread.

"It's my body you idiot, you're lying on top of me!"

"What?"

"Can't you tell?" Catra squirms and pushes her hips up to make a point.

"Ow... I can now."

She can definitely tell that it's Catra now. And that makes her feel something she probably shouldn't be feeling right now because they're locked in a box and because they were fighting just a moment ago.

She tries to search for the lid.

"What... no, don't squirm, there's not enough room!..." Catra tries to move away from under her.

Because she can definitely tell it's Adora too. And that makes her feel something that she knows will just make her feel frustrated. Because they'll get out of this box, and nothing will change, they'll just keep fighting each other. Because Adora has made her choice.

"Adora, stop."

Adora goes still. They both do. But that just makes it worse. Because now it also reminds of a cuddle. And they both know it's something that they've lost, something they can no longer have.

"I think there's a lid, but it's locked," Adora says, her voice cracking. "I can also hear machine noise outside. You know, if I could turn into She-Ra..."

"Don't you dare!"

"But then I'd be able to break us out easily!"

"You're lying on top of me!"

"Oh, she's not that heavy," Adora says tersely. "I'm sure you could bear her weight."

"Are you even hearing yourself right now?" Catra says.

"You know what I meant!" Adora says, slightly panicky. "Ok, hold on..."

"What are you doing?"

"Pulling out my sword! Don't move!"

"Adora!"

"There!"

There's a sound of the sword transforming, and the lid of the box gets pushed up, broken by an extendable staff Adora has in her hand now.

They scramble out and find themselves in a long dim room with a low ceiling, with wires and machinery parts covering the walls. The compartment they were in looks like something where the robots that Entrapta had never got to build would've been stored when idling. It seems like they must be at the very bottom of the train now.

Catra studies Adora's disheveled state, her flushed cheeks, her hair escaping her poof. There's a scratch on her cheek but she

isn't sure if it was her or their fall. She probably doesn't look much better herself.

"Catra..." Adora starts.

"Let's just go," Catra mutters. "Find whoever is doing this."

There's a faint light coming from behind a partially closed door at the end of the room and they start carefully advancing towards it, Adora opting not to transform because of the very low ceiling. Catra swivels her ears, trying to make out if anyone might be there, but the hum of the train's machinery is loud down here and that makes it difficult. On the plus side it's probably masked the noise they were making.

Adora carefully pushes the door, letting them see into the next room. And here, in the middle of it, sits the hooded figure, with its back turned to them.

It hears the door creak and tenses, slowly turns, revealing its face...

"*Sea Hawk*?!!" Adora gasps.

"Um... Surprise?" he says, startled.

Someone else peeks out from behind him.

"*Kyle*?!!" Catra rasps.

"Sorry, Force Captain Catra..."

They can see now that the two sit at a crate that serves as a makeshift table, on which they have snacks and goblets of drinks and play a deck of cards.

"What the f-"

*

"-inally!" Mermista spots Adora and Catra walking towards the refreshments car in the corridor. "Are you okay? We've heard noises, we thought someone was being murdered. Glimmer teleported into the tunnel but she couldn't find you."

"Wild Cat, you're okay!"

A sound of a teleport comes and Glimmer materializes with Bow.

"Did you... Adora!" She throws herself on her neck. "I'm so glad you're okay, we were searching for you..."

Bow joins in the hug.

Everyone else is present and looks relieved to see them, each side their own, at least.

"No... No one was being murdered," Adora shakes her head, looking bewildered. "That was just me and Catra. Talking."

"Someone might still get murdered today," Catra steps to the side, revealing Sea Hawk and Kyle behind her.

The explosion of reactions that follows covers a range from joy by Mermista and Lonnie with Rogelio to open mouthed astonishment by Scorpia and Perfuma.

"Then... there was no murder?" Frosta says, confused.

"Nope." Adora says. "This whole thing was a set up. He wasn't dead, and he was the one in the hood." She tiredly slumps into a chair.

Catra just silently glares.

"I need to sit down," Scorpia says.

"Sea Hawk, are you insane?" Mermista balls her fists and advances at him. "You made me think we were in danger!"

"But my dearest... We were already in danger from the Horde's imminent attack?" He backs away.

"That's not the point! You made us think someone was hurt!"

It's unlikely that she means Kyle.

"You do care..." Sea Hawk nearly tears up. "Forgive me my dearest Mermista. I only wanted to surprise you. You were spending almost all of your time with your other friends lately, and I thought if I could do something nice for you... You like the Mer-Mystery books so much, so I thought what could be a better surprise than to live one? I was going to leave a few more clues so you could find the 'murderer' and discover it was me... I thought it would be fun?" His back reaches the wall and he has no further means of escaping.

Mermista still looks furious. But she also deflates a little.

She gives him a glare. "You and I are going to have a long and serious talk about this. But yeah..." She smiles contemplatively. "I guess this was kinda fun. Now that I know no one was dead or was going to die." She smirks. "Also, for the future, just in case - making it the obvious one when everyone thinks it can't be the obvious one is kiiiiiind of cheating." She looks pleased nonetheless.

Sea Hawk grins. "Oh! You'll need this!" He produces the train control assembly.

"Oh! Really?" Perfuma throws her hands up in an uncharacteristic display of indignation. "So are we going to just be okay with this? It was terrifying! Frosta was traumatized!"

"Are you kidding me?" Frosta says, excited. "Murder mystery, creepy train, dead bodies - that was AWESOME!"

Everyone stares at her again.

"Okay." Perfuma says. "You and I are really going to need to have a meditation on the topic of the difference between fiction and reality."

"And you and I should talk about how shooting taser at people is really not cool," Glimmer glares at Sea Hawk.

"Um... sorry about that. But I was missing on purpose!"

"Hey, we're glad you're okay," Lonnie nudges Kyle and Rogelio wraps his arm around his shoulders with a pleased growl.

"He's so not." Catra glares. "He's going to explain this to Hordak."

"But... I didn't do anything! He really shot me with a tranquilizer dart and then I spent all that time in that room, because I didn't know how to get out. And he wouldn't tell me." Kyle gives Sea Hawk an accusing look, despite the fact that he was taking part in a train heist and probably has got off easy.

"Then how did he know how to detach our ship?" Catra bares her fangs.

"It wasn't me who detached your wonderful ship," Sea Hawk says.

"Then who the hell did?..."

Everyone looks around in alarm. Is it not over yet? Is there *another* mystery on the train?

A real murderer?

"Hiiiiiiii!" Entrapta bounds up. "It was me." She waves with her datapad that lets her control things remotely.

"You." Catra stares at her, rooted in place. "You did this?"

"Yup!"

Catra lets out a decidedly unhinged chuckle. "What is wrong with you! You were the one who told Hordak we needed the ore! And

then you just went and sabotaged my mission? Do you realize what you did? Why did you even do it?" she yells, her hair falling out from her head piece.

Adora looks at her, concerned.

"Oh, we didn't really need the ore that badly," Entrapta says, unperturbed. "I can complete all my projects using something else, it just would've been more effective with the ore. And when I saw what was happening here I really wanted to find out how this social experiment would play out, it was so fascinating! And I wasn't sure if we were staying, so... I decided I would simply tell Hordak that your mission was a resounding success and you got us the ore we wanted and that I'm using it for my projects."

Catra stares at her.

"You will tell him that?"

"Correct!"

"Why didn't you say anything to me?"

"It would've really messed up the conditions of the experiment and the data collection."

"Entrapta, I want you to listen to me very carefully. If you ever do something like this again..."

"I won't! I don't have to. The experiment was a dazzling success, I've gathered so much data! Analyzing it could take months! Maybe years!"

"Okay. Okay. Can someone please explain how did he do this?!" Bow says.

"Honestly Bow, do you really want to know?..." Adora says tiredly.

"The reveal about how the murderer did it is the best part!" Mermista exclaims.

"That's right!" Sea Hawk says, feeling like he's been fully vindicated and striking a heroic pose. "I learned about the robot tunnel from a former Dryl factory worker I met in Seaworthy. And then, the first time I switched off the lights, using a copy of the remote I asked him to make me which could work without the control assembly, I used my impressive blindfolded darts skills, expertly making Kyle stumble into the next car, and locking the door, again with the remote, while managing to slip into the tunnel at the same time with no one noticing, and then the second time I switched off the lights..."

Only Sea Hawk could've conceived of something like this and then actually get lucky enough to pull it off. Adora takes the control assembly from the table and heads to install it.

Catra watches her go.

*

Seabed rushes towards the front window as Adora stands alone in the train's cabin, gazing outside. The assembly had installed without a problem, and they got control of the train back.

She feels hesitant about rejoining the others in the refreshments car however. Catra is there, and... It's stupid, she wants to be around her, to talk to her. To make the best of this time that suddenly fell on them. But she can't think of anything to say. Hey Catra, how's the weather in the Fright Zone? - Well if you hadn't left me Adora, you wouldn't have to ask! Somehow it always comes back to this. And if she did try to convince her again, wouldn't it just end with more fighting too? Maybe it's better to leave it like this? To have one good memory of this normal interaction they've been having after getting out of that box, when they weren't trying to hurt each other and were angry at someone else for a change.

Will this be as normal as it ever gets for them?

"She said she wanted to come talk to you," she hears Glimmer's voice from the entrance and turns to see Catra following her inside.

"And she didn't want me to go alone," Catra says. "Probably thought I might try to murder you or something." She air quotes 'murder'.

"Ugh. With this train I'm not ruling anything out until we're back on the shore," Glimmer says. "By the way, you missed Sea Hawk explaining how he blocked the outer doors just to make all this seem more sinister." She rolls her eyes.

Adora gazes at Catra, feeling glad they're going to talk despite everything. She glances at Glimmer, suddenly feeling self-conscious, as if her friend is witnessing something personal. Her conversations with Catra do tend to feel that way.

Catra glances at Glimmer too. "About that... What happens when we get to the shore?"

Because that fragile truce which is still happening in the refreshments car right now, with everyone still coming to their senses after the revelation, is not going to last. Sooner or later someone will ask this question, and Catra prefers to take initiative.

Adora keeps silent for a moment.

"Just this once, Catra. Because you helped us," she says, feeling like she needs to justify it.

"What, just like that?" Glimmer says. "Shouldn't we discuss this?" She teleports out, to let others know.

Looks like her plan of making herself useful worked. But somehow that doesn't make Catra feel particularly smug or even happy.

They stay silent for a moment, not sure how to continue. Dim ripples of light from the window softly play on their faces.

A faint smile crosses Adora's lips and she utters, remembering something.

"This is not because I like you."

Catra snorts quietly. She didn't entirely mean it back when she said that. And despite herself her mind goes back to that moment with something like longing.

"So, was your plan for stealing the ore really complicated?" Adora asks conversationally.

Catra looks at her face, at her genuinely curious, earnest expression, into her deep blue-gray eyes and for a moment something inside her shakes loose, breaks back to the surface.

"It was pretty brilliant. You would've been really impressed."

Like Adora had always been when she'd come up with a clever way to trick Kyle or to sneak in somewhere they weren't allowed back in the Fright Zone. Back when Adora was her friend.

"Oh, I'm sure of it," Adora says, and she knows that despite needing to save Etheria from the Horde she really would've been. She'll always be impressed with Catra. And she'll never stop wanting them to be friends again.

"Catra..." she says.

Catra flinches slightly. "I better go. Check to see if Sparkles isn't undermining your decision."

She turns to the doors. She glances at Adora before she exits, something unreadable crossing her eyes, and disappears in the darkness.

Adora keeps looking the way she's gone.

*

"Oh there you are girl, come to momma!" Scorpia urgently beckons her ship towards herself with her pincers as it drifts over the remaining patch of water and the waves push it out onto a sandy beach. She encompasses its nose in a hug. "Are you alright? Did anyone hurt my baby?"

Catra watches her, sitting on the deck of a skiff nearby with her feet dangling over the sand.

"I think she's okay!" Scorpia calls out to her. "I don't see any scratches."

She keeps watching as Scorpia secures and checks her ship, and as Etheria's glowing sky slowly turns red over the horizon.

"Ah, so glad that everything's turned out well," Scorpia sits down next to her, lowering her feet over the edge too. "Pointionita is okay, Hordak was pleased and totally bought that ore story, no one got captured or killed..."

She glances at Catra, noticing that she's having one of her broody horizon gazing moods.

"I just wish we could've done your heist plan," she says sympathetically. "That would've been fun."

Catra glances at her and pulls her feet up to the deck, wrapping her tail around her ankles.

"The next ore shipment is in a few months. Maybe we can try again then," she says.

She gazes at the ever changing waves.

"We have time."

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